

The Battle of Gettysburg took place in 1863. After three days of fighting and the death of more than 7,000 soldiers, the Confederate army was forced to retreat.

trumped the authority of the federal, or central, government in Washington. This question repeatedly resurfaced as territories in the west were settled and sought admission to the Union: would they be slave or “free” states?

The 1820 Missouri Compromise stated that slavery would be allowed only in new states south of a line extending westward from the southern border of Missouri. It was later agreed that the settlers of new states should decide for themselves whether theirs would be free or slave states—a decision that was reinforced by the Kansas-Nebraska Act of 1854. Since

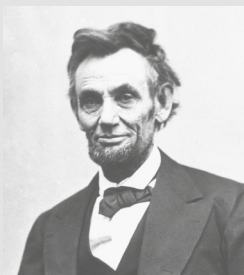
both Kansas and Nebraska were to the north of Missouri’s southern border, what followed, in Kansas above all, was a sudden inrush of pro- and anti-slavery settlers, each desperate to prevail. The two sides clashed repeatedly and violently.

The South breaks away

This conflict led to the founding of a new anti-slavery party, the Republicans, on whose ticket Abraham Lincoln, with practically no support from any slave state, was voted into office in November 1860. Lincoln’s victory prompted the almost immediate decision by South Carolina to secede, to leave the Union. By February, a further six Southern states had broken away, and the seven declared themselves a new nation: the Confederate States of America. By May, when Richmond in Virginia was made the capital of the new country, four more states had joined them. However, five slave states, the so-called Border States, opted to remain within the original Union.

The Confederacy argued that the Constitution had been freely adopted, and as such any state could legitimately break away from the Union if it felt oppressed. As free-born men, the citizens of the South had an “inalienable” right to shape their own destinies, just as the founding fathers had when they rejected the tyranny of »

Abraham Lincoln



When he arrived in Washington in February 1861 for his presidential inauguration, Abraham Lincoln (1809–1865) was

widely dismissed in political circles as an ignorant, socially awkward backwoodsman. By the time of his assassination just four years later, he had come to dominate America. Lincoln had not just won the Civil War, but he had also established himself as a kind of irresistible political oracle.

Born in a log cabin in Kentucky, Lincoln qualified as a lawyer by his late 20s. He became an increasingly articulate champion of what would emerge as the anti-slavery Republican party. Despite having no

military experience, Lincoln proved an increasingly shrewd judge of how the Civil War should best be fought, actively arguing in favor of General Grant. He never lost sight of his wider aims: the maintenance of American liberties and the essential dignity of humanity. He pushed on with the war with unflinching determination, yet he understood precisely what loss of life on the scale of the Civil War meant.